

Table 3.1 : Total Population, Intercensal Increase and Average Annual Growth Rate by Census Year, 1871 - 2024

Census Date	Total Population	Intercensal Increase		Average Annual Growth Rate (%)
		Number	Percentage	
27 March 1871	2,400,380	-	-	-
17 February 1881	2,759,738	359,358	15.0	1.4
26 February 1891	3,007,789	248,051	9.0	0.9
01 March 1901	3,565,954	558,165	18.6	1.7
10 March 1911	4,106,350	540,396	15.2	1.4
18 March 1921	4,498,605	392,255	9.6	0.9
26 February 1931	5,306,871	808,266	18.0	1.7
19 March 1946	6,657,339	1,350,468	25.4	1.5
20 March 1953	8,097,895	1,440,556	21.6	2.8
08 July 1963	10,582,064	2,484,169	30.7	2.6
09 October 1971	12,689,897	2,107,833	19.9	2.2
17 March 1981	14,846,750	2,156,853	17.0	1.7
17 July 2001 ¹	18,797,257	3,950,507	26.6	1.2
20 March 2012	20,359,439	1,562,182	8.3	0.7
19 December 2024	21,781,800	1,422,361	7.0	0.5

Table 3.1 shows the population growth of Sri Lanka from 1871 to 2024. The period 1946–1963 was an era of rapid population growth, with the highest intercensal growth rate of 30.7 percent reported in the 1963 census. The highest average annual growth rate of 2.8 percent was reported in the 1953 census.

At the Census of Population and Housing - 2024 the total population of Sri Lanka was 21,781,800. Accordingly, the percentage of intercensal increase is 7 percent, and the average annual growth rate is 0.5 percent. In the 2012 census, the percentage of intercensal increase was 8.3 percent, and the average annual growth rate was 0.7 percent. Although the average annual growth rate further declined to 0.5 percent in this census, the fact that it remains a positive value indicates that Sri Lanka's population has continued to increase gradually, albeit at a slower pace.

¹ Note: Since the census work in the districts of Jaffna, Mannar, Vavuniya, Mullaitivu, Kilinochchi in the Northern Province and the districts of Batticaloa and Trincomalee in the Eastern Province was not completed in the 2001 census, the estimates for the entire country, which were finally calculated after estimating the population for those districts, are given under Population 2001.